How School Leaders Matter

Teachers, classrooms, and families under mandatory principal turnover

Paper idea for discussion. October 2026

This paper

School principals are an input in the education production function: value-added estimates put a one standard deviation better principal at 0.05 to 0.10 SD of student achievement. Much less is known about the production process itself: how leadership translates into teacher behavior, classroom organization, and family engagement, and through them into learning.

We study this process using mandatory principal turnover in Madrid's public primary schools. Two institutional rules, compulsory retirement at 65 and a twelve-year limit on tenure, generate leadership transitions whose timing is unrelated to school performance. Linked administrative and survey data on every principal, teacher, classroom, pupil, and parent let us estimate the effect of a leadership change on each intermediate outcome, not only on test scores.

Teacher practice, wellbeing, and collaboration, classroom climate, and parental engagement are treated as outcomes in their own right, and as the channels through which leadership reaches achievement.

What we know

Leaders matter	A one SD better principal raises achievement by 0.05 to 0.10 SD (Branch, Hanushek, and Rivkin, 2012; Böhlmark, Grönqvist, and Vlachos, 2016). The effect is comparable to a teacher's, over a whole school (Grissom, Egalite, and Lindsay, 2021).
Changes matter	When the principal changes, achievement falls by about 0.03 SD the next year and teacher turnover rises (Bartanen, Grissom, and Rogers, 2019).
Leadership and the school	Where teachers value their principal's instructional and relational leadership, schools show better climate, more collaboration, better classroom management, higher wellbeing and job satisfaction (OECD, TALIS 2018). Correlational.

What has been opened, and what has not

Personnel	Effective principals keep their best teachers and lose their weakest (Grissom and Bartanen, 2019, AERJ). Principals reshape the staff through hiring and retention (Bartanen and Grissom, 2023, JHR). Who teaches in the school is the channel the literature has identified.
Procedures	For superintendents, better leaders change school priorities, working procedures and violence (Lavy, Boiko, and Rachkovski, 2023, EJ).
Not yet seen	Under a change of leader the school did not choose: what the same teachers do and how they feel, how classrooms are run, and how families respond. The inside of the school.

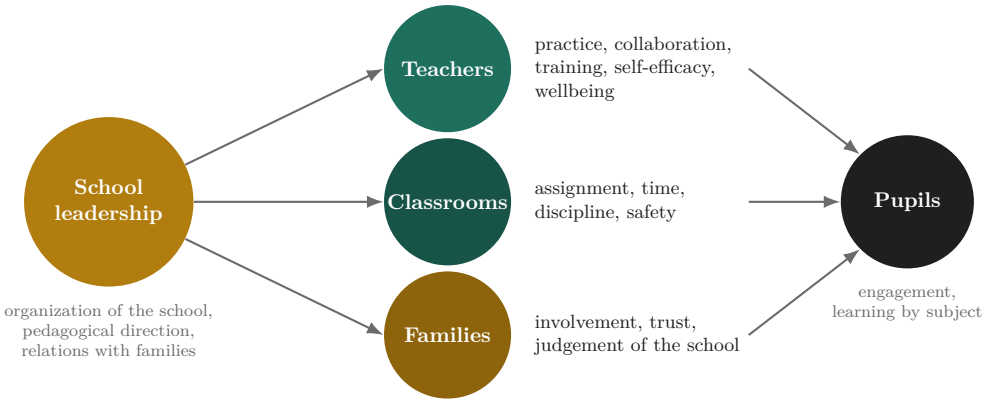
The literature shows that leaders matter and that they choose who teaches. This paper is about what they do with the teachers they have.

Intermediate outcomes: what we observe at the school level

Teachers	Reported classroom practice, collaboration, participation in training, self-efficacy, and wellbeing.
Classrooms	Allocation of teachers and support hours across groups, disciplinary climate, and pupils' reports of safety and bullying.
Families	Involvement in the school, satisfaction with teachers and the centre, and perceptions of school quality.
Pupils	Engagement, perceptions of the school, and standardized achievement by subject.

Each domain is measured for every school and year. Teacher and family outcomes enter the analysis as dependent variables, and jointly as mediators of the effect on achievement.

Causal map



All nodes are observed for the universe of schools. Exogenous variation enters at the leadership node.

Setting

Institutions	Spanish principals are teachers selected from the staff for four-year terms. Staffing, pay, and curriculum are set by the regional administration. A change of principal therefore changes leadership and organization while holding the teaching staff fixed, which separates the leadership effect from the personnel channel identified in the US literature.
Exogenous timing	Terms end by compulsory retirement at 65 and by a limit of twelve years in office, both determined years in advance. Transitions induced by these rules are orthogonal to contemporaneous school shocks.
Successor characteristics	Incoming principals come from the same staff and are observed as classroom teachers in the year before appointment, which provides pre-determined measures of their type.
Data	Universe of public primary schools in Madrid, 2015 to 2018: principal and teacher questionnaires, timetables, and census surveys and standardized tests of all pupils and parents by classroom.

Identification: a principal's clock



Treated	Schools whose clock runs out in 2016, 2017, or 2018: a new leader arrives for reasons unrelated to the school's trajectory.
Comparison	Schools whose clock runs out later. Staggered event study on the calendar; 2SLS for the realized change.
Benchmark	Exits that are not rule-based (resignations, non-renewals), kept separate: they carry the selection the literature worries about (Miller, 2013; Bartanen, Grissom, and Rogers, 2019).
Heterogeneity	By the successor's pre-appointment practices and wellbeing, the selection committee's score of their project, and the staff's assessment of the outgoing principal.

Outcomes and expected timing

Outcome	What a new leader may change	Measured with	When
Classrooms	Assignment of teachers and support hours across groups	Schedules, class composition	Year 1
Classrooms	Discipline and climate	Pupil and teacher reports	Years 1–2
Families	Involvement, trust, judgement of the school	Parent survey	Years 1–2
Teachers	Self-efficacy, wellbeing, collaboration, training	Teacher survey	Years 1–2
Teachers	Classroom practice of the same teachers	Teacher survey, within teacher	Years 2–3
Pupils	Engagement and learning, by subject	Pupil survey, standardized tests	Last

Pre-registered indices by domain. Achievement is the final outcome; intermediate domains are expected to respond first.

Estimands

Average effect	The effect of a mandatory leadership transition on each domain: teachers, classrooms, families, achievement.
Variance of leader effects	If leaders differ, the dispersion of outcome changes is larger around rule-based transitions than in non-transition years (Jones and Olken, 2005). Identified without classifying leaders.
Heterogeneity	Treatment effects by pre-determined characteristics of the incoming and outgoing principal: prior classroom practice, project score, staff assessment.

The three together identify whether leadership matters, how much leaders differ, and which observable characteristics predict effective leadership.

Data

In hand	Universe of Madrid public primary schools, 2015 to 2018. Principal questionnaire. Teachers: practices, wellbeing, training. Schedules: who teaches which class. All pupils by classroom: scores by subject, perceptions. All parents by classroom: involvement, satisfaction.
To collect	Principal appointments, renewals, and exits with cause (BOCM). The committee's grade of each project. Teacher assignment lists: chosen versus imposed posts. School plans from archived websites. Public school-level results from 2022: the long run.

Open questions

- **Mechanisms to prioritize.** Which intermediate outcomes should respond within the first year of a new principal, and which later?
- **What the data must have.** A stable teacher identifier across years; the principal's age and years in office; the survey items that rate the principal.
- **Sample of rule-based transitions** in 2015 to 2018, and access to appointment records and later years from the Consejería.

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